

How do we take Indian esports from 'event-led' to 'ecosystem-led'?

Akshat: An ecosystem-led model requires three structural changes:

- First, year-long calendars instead of isolated marquee events.
- Second, clearer qualification and ranking systems that allow teams, players and their brand partners to plan seasons rather than tournaments.
- Third, regional and state-level circuits that feed into national and international leagues.

We are moving in the right direction, but this is still a work in progress. Regulatory clarity has helped, and state-backed tournaments are increasing. By 2027, success will depend on how well publishers, organisers, and governments align around common frameworks rather than parallel efforts. Scale alone won't get us there, structure will.

How important is it to expand beyond BGMI and Free Fire, and what will it take to build ecosystems around other titles?

Akshat: It's absolutely essential. India has already lived through what title concentration risk looks like. When the two biggest mobile titles were banned, the esports ecosystem came close to a complete standstill. Teams collapsed, tournaments vanished, brand spends froze, and player careers were abruptly paused. That period made one thing very clear that no ecosystem of this scale can afford to be dependent on one or two titles, no matter how successful they are.

To build resilience, India needs parallel esports ecosystems across mobile, PC, and console, each designed around the strengths and realities of that platform. The objective isn't to replace BGMI or Free Fire, but to ensure the industry can absorb shocks and continue growing even if one pillar weakens.

India's next phase of esports growth depends on diversification, patience, and long-term publisher

commitment. If we get that right, India will finally move beyond being a one- or two-title market into a truly multi-ecosystem esports nation.

Do you think an Indian-developed game can become a major esports by 2027?

Akshat: It's possible, but it has to be realistic. The strongest candidates will come from culturally intuitive genres – sports, strategy, or globally understandable formats rather than trying to mimic Western shooters.

Cricket-based titles like Real Cricket, especially with backing from publishers like KRAFTON, have genuine export potential. Success will depend less on development alone and more on long-term publishing support, competitive infrastructure, and international positioning.

How crucial are grassroots leagues like colleges, city tournaments, and café circuits?

Akshat: They are foundational. Grassroots ecosystems are where esports shifts from being aspirational to being accessible. College leagues, city tournaments, and café circuits lower entry barriers, regionalise participation, and allow talent to surface outside the usual metro-heavy pipelines.

This layer is no longer theoretical. When you take structured competition directly to campuses participation scales rapidly and talent discovery becomes far more organic. First-time competitors get a legitimate starting point before they've even considered esports as a career.

Beyond talent, grassroots leagues also create localised fandom. When players represent their colleges, cities, or cafés, audiences connect more deeply and consistently. That emotional attachment is what eventually feeds national leagues and global stages. With it, you unlock a pipeline that is wider, younger, and far more representative of India's gaming population.

How mainstream can esports become in India by 2027? Can it rival the IPL?

Akshat: Esports shouldn't be measured against the IPL, they serve different cultural roles. What esports can achieve by 2027 is normalisation. Televised tournaments, non-endemic sponsors, and cross-generational acceptance is already becoming standard. By several measures like digital viewership, youth participation, and time spent, esports is already among the third largest sports in the country after Cricket and Kabaddi.

What will it take for India to become a top esports hub in Asia by 2027?

Akshat: For India to realistically become a top esports hub in Asia, two major stimulants need to align.

First, an Indian professional team needs to break through and consistently dominate at the global level in a major international title. Second, India needs a new sport to emerge with a large player base that does not carry geopolitical or regulatory uncertainty. Until these two shifts happen, India will continue to be viewed as a high-potential market rather than a true Asian esports hub.

What further support would you like from policymakers?

Akshat: Recognition has happened. Now the focus should be operational clarity. Single-window clearances for tournaments, smoother athlete visa and travel processes, and consistent state-level policies would unlock the next phase of growth. The industry doesn't need subsidies, it needs predictability and execution support.

Your message to young Indians and parents considering gaming as a career?

Akshat: For young people who approach gaming seriously, balancing it with academics and personal development, it can be a credible and rewarding career path. For parents, the key isn't blind encouragement or rejection, but informed guidance. **d**